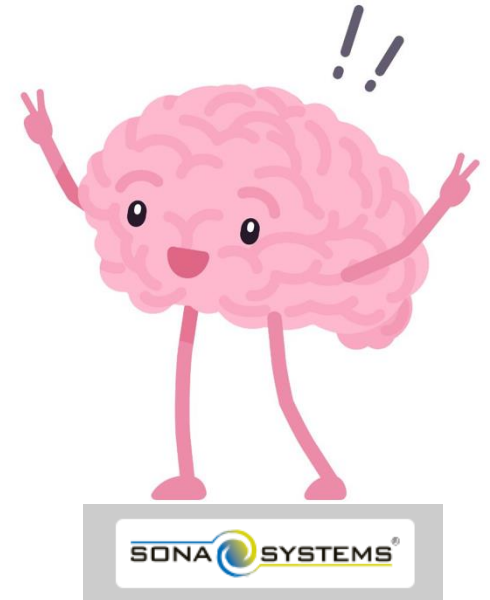




Taking part in Psychological Research at LU & The **SONA** System

For PSYC4141 and PSYC4242 Students

Dr Ruth Hurley r.hurley@lancaster.ac.uk





Overview

Taking part in Psychological Research
& The LU **SONA** System

1. [Research at LU Psychology.](#)
2. [Study recruitment using SONA.](#)
3. [Y1 Course requirements and SONA learning outcomes.](#)
4. [TASK: Take part in your first study.](#)
5. [Tips on collecting your SONA credits.](#)
6. [SONA Support](#)

1

We have a thriving research community at Lancaster - One of Lancaster's many strengths

[Research - Lancaster University](#)



Developmental Psychology

How do we develop an understanding of the world around us? We look at cognitive, social, emotional and language development from before birth through to adolescence.

e.g. Early cognitive Development, curiosity



Cognitive Psychology

What are the fundamental cognitive processes behind language, learning, memory, and attention? How does our understanding of cognition impact society?

e.g. Language, emotion, consciousness



Neuroscience and Neurocognition

How does the brain respond to different environments and govern cognitive function? We research how humans understand and process the world around us.

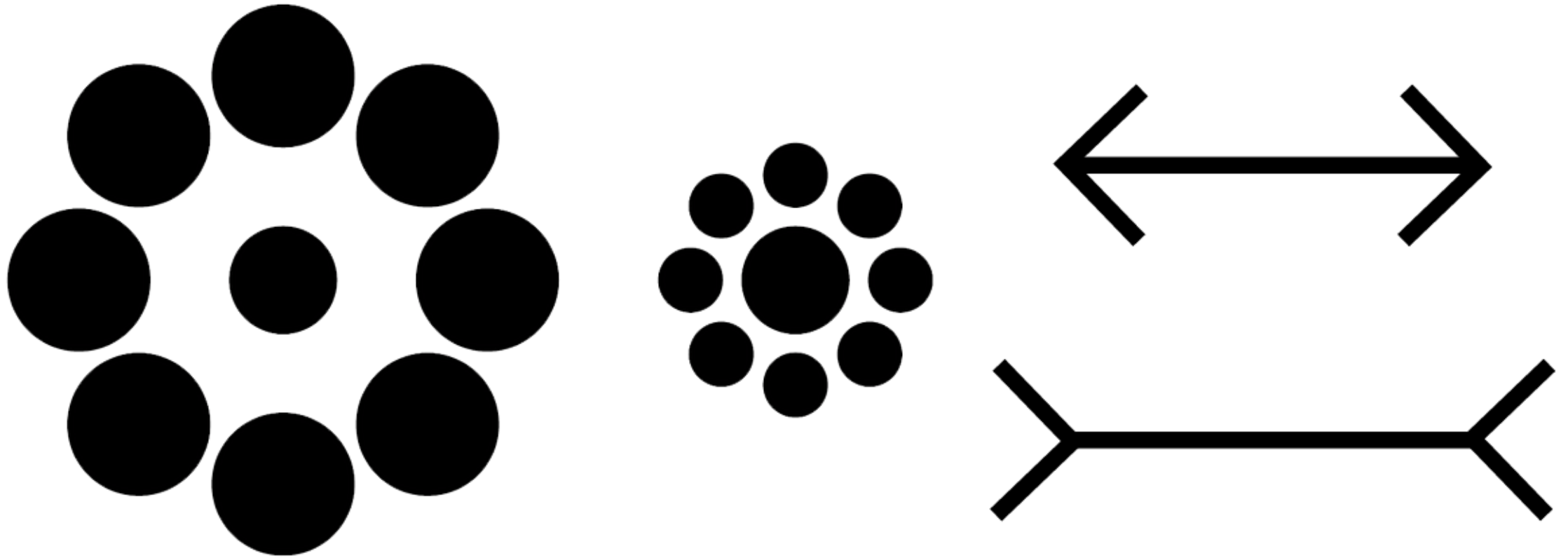


Social Processes

How do we develop definitions of morality or trust, and how do they affect our emotions in social interaction or decision making?

e.g. Forensic, cyber/technology

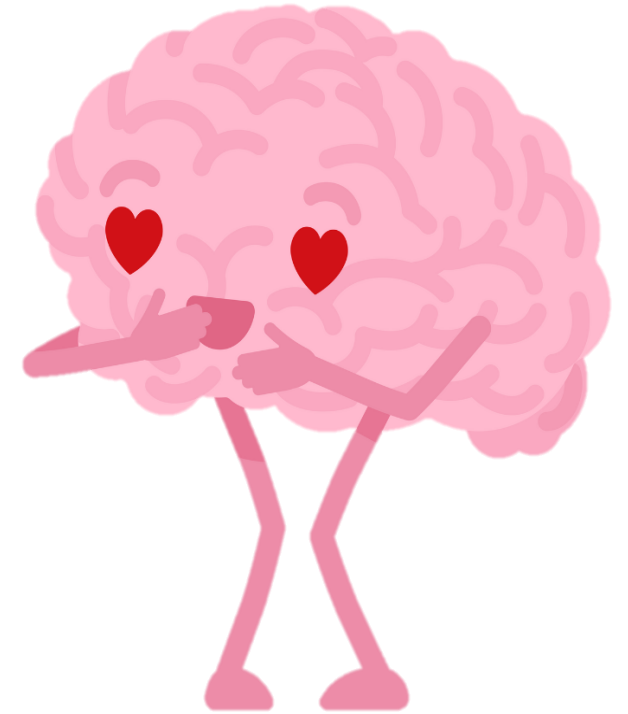
Here are some example findings from research conducted in the department1:



Children are less susceptible to some illusions (for example the Ebbinghaus illusion, left), while more susceptible to others (like the Muller-Lyer illusion, right) – Research by Radoslaw Wincza

Here are some example findings from research conducted in the department2:

Reddit data was analysed from the r/relationships subreddit and found that men discussed the topic of “heartbreak” more than women in the sample (N = 184,631). This shows men are more emotionally invested than previously thought (challenging gender stereotypes), and likely equal to women in this regard.
– Research by Charlotte Entwistle



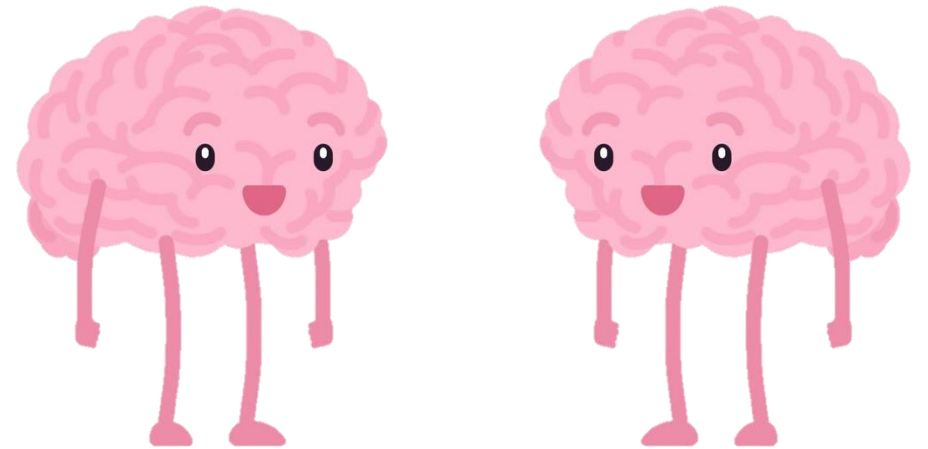
Here are some example findings from research conducted in the department3:

Autistic defendants are judged to appear more honest and less blameworthy once they disclose their diagnosis to the jury.

– Research by Tiegan Blackhurst

AI-synthesized faces are indistinguishable from real faces and more trustworthy

– Research by Sophie Nightingale



Here are some example findings from research conducted in the department4:

People often choose smaller benefits for themselves now rather than helping future generations, especially in situations related to climate change. However, this tendency can be reduced by sharing messages that encourage people to think about the positive legacy they can leave for future generations.

– Research by Mark Hurlstone



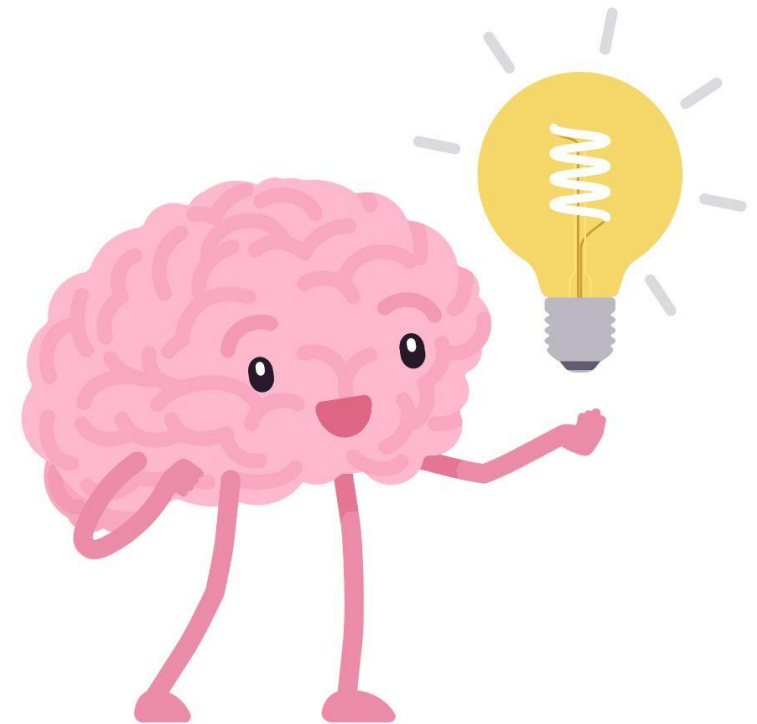
Here are some example findings from research conducted in the department5:

The ability to think about and imagine future events (episodic future thinking) has an impact on how well someone can tell the truth or tell a lie.

– Research by Fliss O’Connell

Words that sound similar to one another are more likely to mean similar things, and this is especially true for the words that we first acquire.

– Research by Padraic Monaghan



People like
you make
discoveries
possible!



How as a department do we recruit research participants?



Database to securely manage research participation.

- People sign up to the system as a participant.
- Researchers advertise their projects on the system.

Who are the 'researchers' using SONA?

Psychology researchers, including:

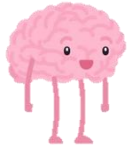
- PEP Students
- Third year dissertation students
- MSc Students
- PhD Students
- Post Doc/Research Associates
- Lecturers



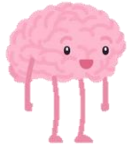
Who are the participants using SONA, and why?



- **Psychology students.** All Y1 take part in research for **course credit (SONA points)** and research experience.



- **Lancaster award students** take part in research to gain **Campus activity or volunteering hours.**



- **Any LU Student/staff** can sign up to take part in paid studies advertised on the system (for **vouchers or direct credit payment**).

(only one type of recompense for your time).

Adults with an active LU email account.
NB can be 17+

What to expect as a research participant:

- Study information

(e.g., info on data security, ethical approval, what you will be doing and approximately how long the study will take)

- Consent form
- Participant ID
- Debrief (some information may be withheld at the start)
- How to withdraw
- Credits granted (or for payment)

Eligibility Criteria for Studies

Some studies may state that only certain people can take part. Why?

Ensuring Safety:

Some psychological studies may involve procedures or interventions that are not suitable for all individuals. Eligibility criteria help ensure the safety of participants by excluding those who may be at risk due to the nature of the study.

Enhancing Validity:

Eligibility criteria help enhance the validity of a study. By ensuring that participants have certain characteristics (e.g., age, gender, medical history), researchers can control for extraneous variables that might otherwise affect the results.

Targeting Specific Populations: Some studies aim to investigate psychological phenomena in specific groups of people (e.g., individuals with a particular mental health condition, age group, or cultural background). Eligibility criteria ensures that the study includes only individuals from the target population.

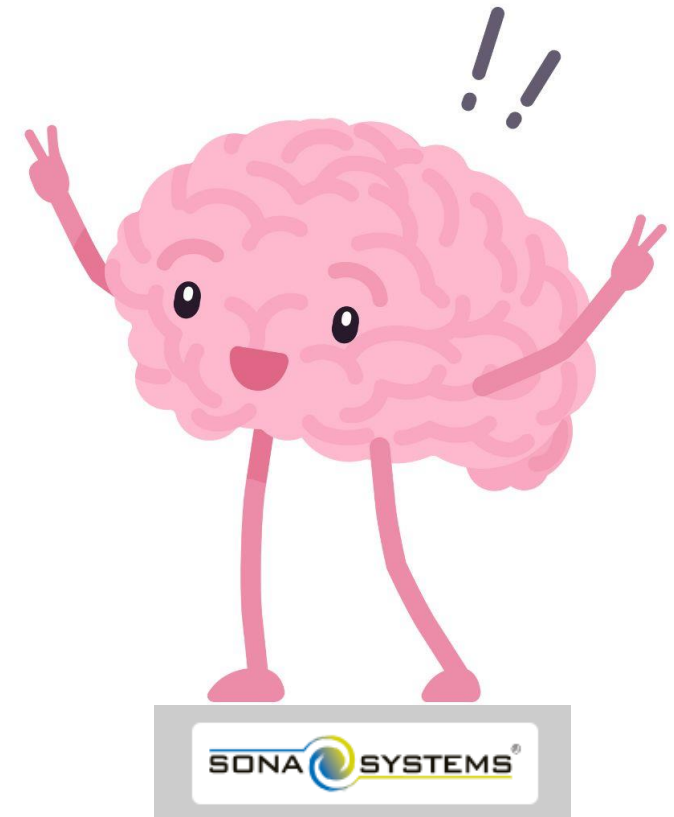
Study Participation Y1 Course Requirements

PSYC4141 and PSYC4242



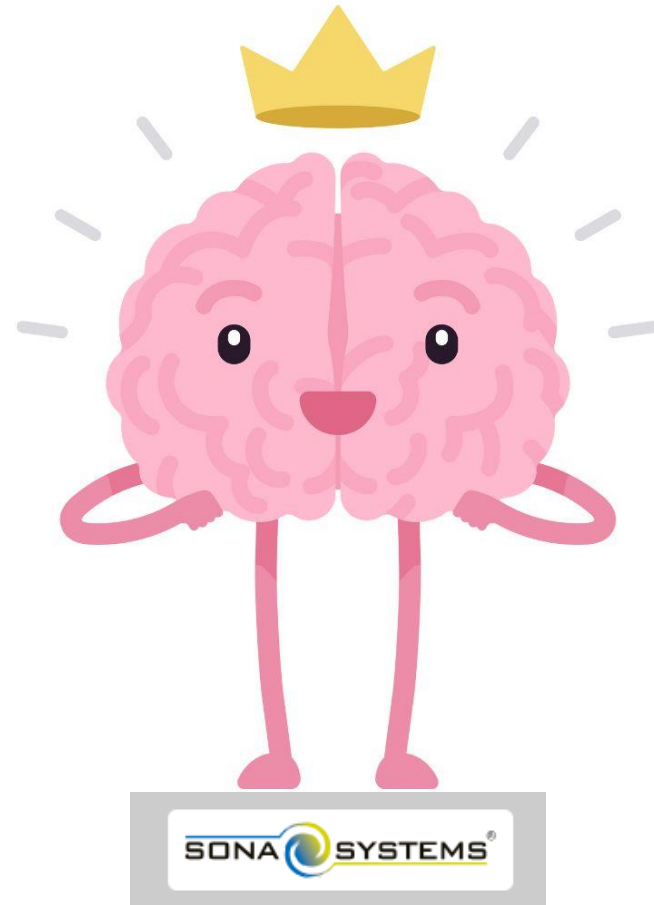
What are the Y1 SONA Assessment requirements on PSYC4141 and PSYC4242?

- Your target is to collect **60 credit points** by week 10 for your SONA assessment on PSYC4141.
- And an additional **60 credits** by week 20 for your SONA assessment on PSYC4242.
- Your grade will depend on the % number of credits collected (60 credits =100% each term).
- You will earn **1 credit point** per 15 minutes of participation in **online research**.
- You will earn **3 credit points** per 15 minutes of participation in **lab-based/in-person research**.



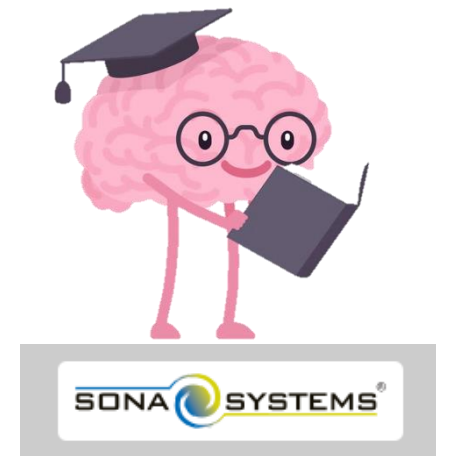
Other benefits:

- Collect your 120 credits and you can use SONA to advertise and recruit 30 participants for your own third year projects.



Why is SONA Participation important for Psychology Students?

PSYC4141 and PSYC4242



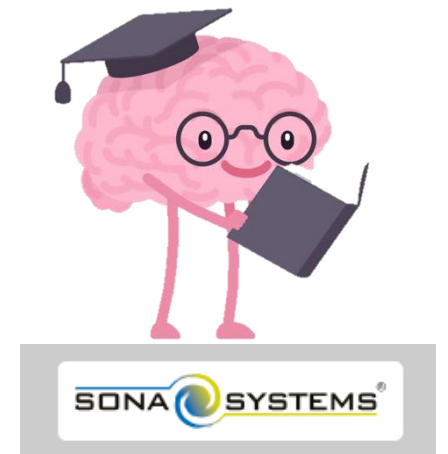
Reasons why taking part in research is a learning activity¹:

1. Understanding Psychological Concepts:

You can gain a deeper understanding of psychological concepts and theories by being a part of research studies. You can see first-hand how these theories are tested and how experiments are conducted, and it can give you ideas for your own final year project.

2. Learn Psychological Insights Beyond Course Content:

By participating in psychological research, you may learn about different aspects of human cognition, emotion, behaviour etc. that you were not previously aware of.



Reasons why taking part in research is a learning activity2:

3. Learning about Research Methods:

You can learn about various research methods used in psychology. You can learn how data is collected, analysed, and interpreted, and how conclusions are drawn from this data.

4. Self-Discovery:

Some psychological research involves introspective processes where you may learn something new about yourself. You may gain insights into your own behaviours, thoughts, and feelings.



Reasons why taking part in research is a learning activity³:

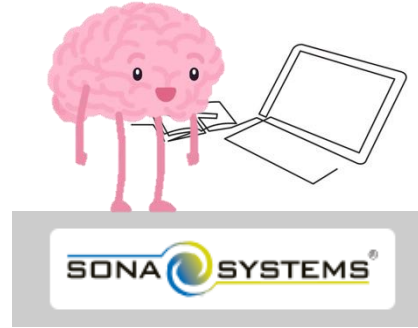
5. Ethical Considerations:

You can learn about the ethical considerations involved in psychological research, including informed consent, confidentiality, and the right to withdraw from a study at any time.

6. Critical Thinking:

Being part of a study can encourage you to think critically about research findings, methodologies, and the application of research to real-world issues, as well as increasing your empathy and understanding of the participant's perspective. This will help you be a better researcher.





Instructions to take part in your first study! **Important**

PSYC4141 SONA Study

The relationship between executive functions
and risk-taking behaviour

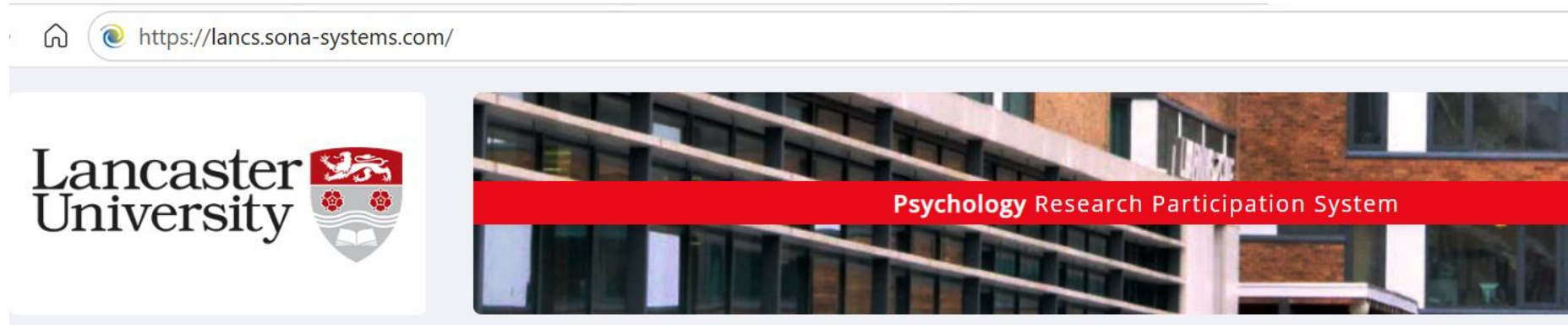
- 2 Credits



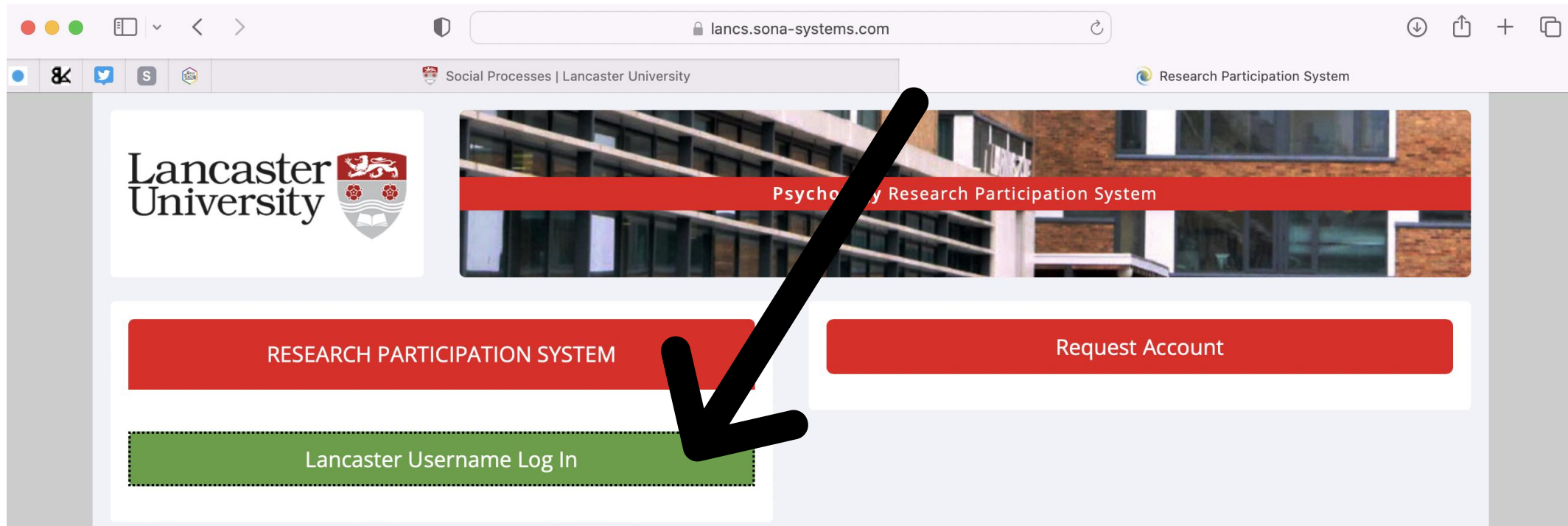
Open LU SONA with the following web address



<https://lancs.sona-systems.com>



https://lancs.sona-systems.com



If you end up clicking “Request Account” OR
Your LU account is not setup yet, please complete this form

[Y1 Psychology Students: SONA
ACCOUNT NEEDED – Fill in form](#)

Log in as
normal

WebLogin



Username



Next

*Please enter your username
and click the "Next" button to
continue.*

By using this service you agree to
adhere to our [policies and
guidelines](#).

[Forgotten your password?](#)

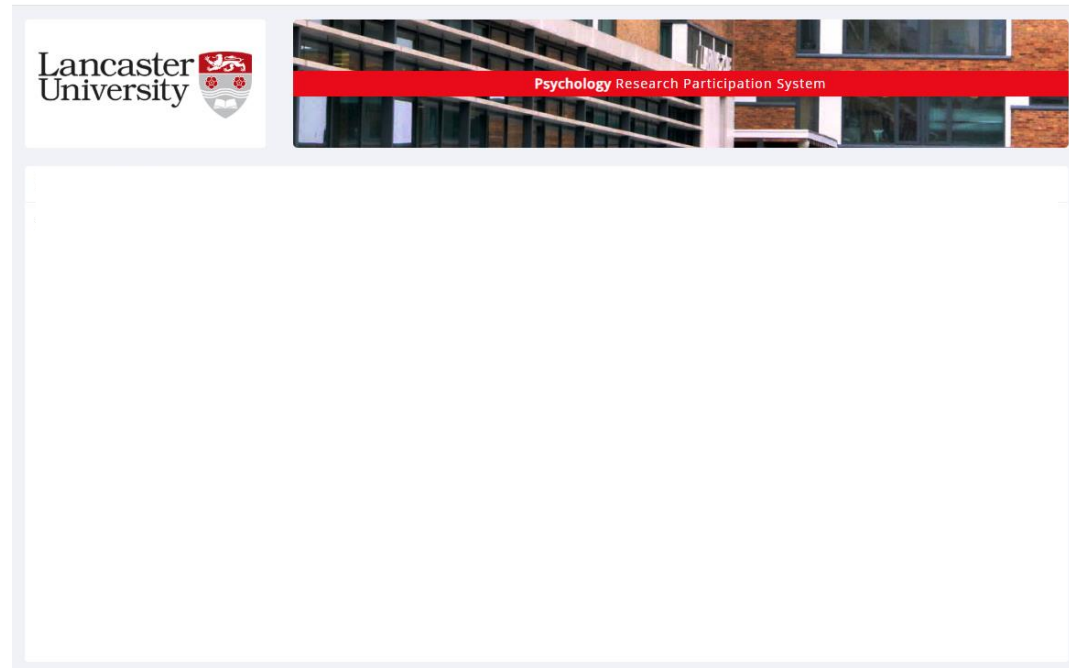
[Problem using Multi-Factor Authentication \(MFA\)?](#)

[Problems logging in?](#)

Lancaster Account Problems?

[IT account | ASK - Lancaster
University](#)

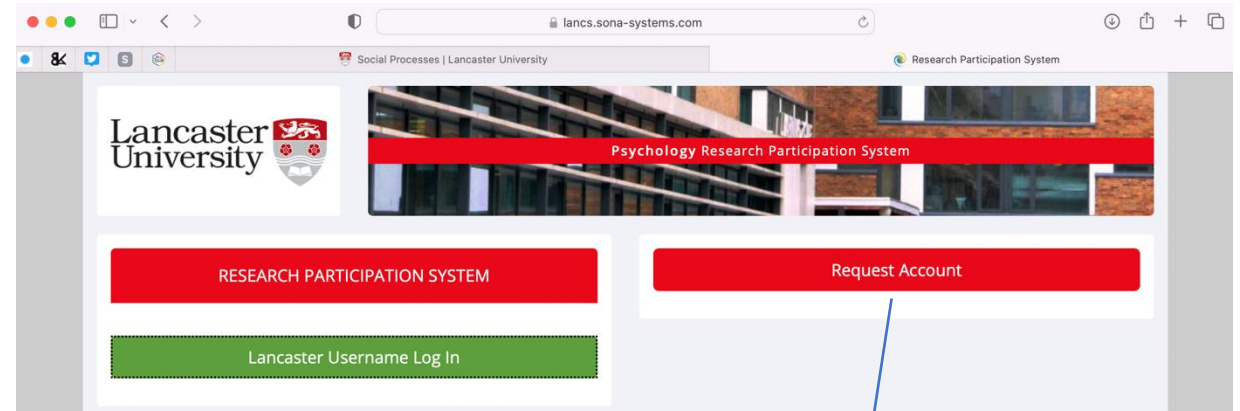
You will access the system as a
'Psych UG Year 1 (credits)'



Problems?

If you end up clicking “Request Account”
e.g. by accident or
because your LU account is not setup yet

OR you have problems making your
account in the first few weeks of term



Please complete this form

[Y1 Psychology Students: SONA
ACCOUNT NEEDED – Fill in form](#)

Browse studies by clicking here



[Home](#) [Studies](#) [My Schedule/Credits](#) [FAQ](#) [My Profile](#) [Logout](#)

Heather Shaw (Participant)

Study Sign-Up

[VIEW AVAILABLE STUDIES](#)

Credits Overview

	0		0
Credits Earned		Credits Pending	

My Schedule & Credits

-  View or cancel my study appointments
-  View studies I've participated in, and see if credit has been granted
-  View other Credits I've earned

Upcoming Appointments

 No Upcoming Appointments

Study information

Study Name	PSYC4141 Students Only: The relationship between executive functions and risk-taking behaviour
Study Type	 Online External Study This study is an online study located on another website. Participants are not given access to the Study URL until after they sign up for the study.
Study Status	Visible to participants : Approved Active study : Appears on list of available studies Online (web) study : Administered outside the system
Duration	30 minutes
Credits	2 Credits
Website	View Study Website Sample Link with Embedded ID Code Qualtrics Redirect to a URL

Restrictions

Course Restrictions

Participants must be in at least one of these courses:

- A. Psych UG year 1 (credits)
- G. Lancaster award Student
- K. Study Abroad student

Additional Study Information

Timeslot Usage Limit	999 hours (approximately 1998 signups)
Participant Sign-Up Deadline	24 hours before the study is to occur
Participant Cancellation Deadline	2 hours before the study is to occur
Department/Uni code Approval Code	
Direct Study Link	https://lancs.sona-systems.com/default.aspx? This is a direct URL for participants to access the

Studies on campus: Select a Timeslot

events). These tasks will be slightly different on each day but they will not be complex in nature. Full details will be provided in the lab sessions.

Outside of the lab sessions, you will be asked to keep a sleep diary for the nights prior to each day in which you are involved in the study. Alongside this, you will be asked to refrain from recreational drug use for one week prior to and during the study, avoid alcohol for 24 hours before each lab session, and limit your caffeine intake to no more than one cup of coffee on the morning of each study day. This is important to help maintain normal sleep patterns and increase the likelihood of falling asleep during the nap sessions.

Please only complete the screening questionnaire if you are also able / willing to take part in the lab sessions.

Eligibility Requirements:
Participants should:

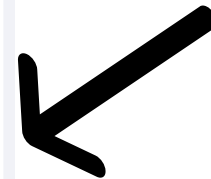
- Be 18-60 years old.
- Have regular sleep schedules; this is considered to be typical bedtimes between 10pm and 2am, and typical wake times between 6am and 10am.
- Have NEVER received a diagnosis of any sleep disorder (e.g., narcolepsy, insomnia, or sleep apnea) OR conditions that may affect sleep (e.g., chronic pain, diabetes, or seizures).
- NOT work night shifts, including working late into the night or early hours of the morning (e.g., working at a nightclub).
- NOT be taking any medication that is known to affect sleep.

PLEASE NOTE: It is possible that your responses on the screening questionnaire will indicate that you are not eligible to take part in the research study. In this event, the research team will not contact you to provide further information or offer you the opportunity to participate in the main study; however, you will still receive 1 SONA credit.

Preparation	Prior to confirming any lab session timeslots, the screening questionnaire must be completed, and eligibility must be confirmed by the research team.
Eligibility Requirements	PLEASE SEE STUDY DESCRIPTION FOR DETAILED ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENTS
Researchers	Sammy Hollings  Leanna Keeble 
Deadlines	Sign-Up: 48 hour(s) before the appointment Cancellation: 24 hour(s) before the appointment

 [View Time Slots for This Study](#)

Email the
researcher



TASK: Login to SONA and click on Available studies

Lancaster University

Psychology Research Participation System

Home Studies My Schedule/Credits FAQ My Profile Logout

Ruth Hurley (Participant)

Please note that **only studies with available time slots are listed**. If there are no studies on this page, this means that there are currently no studies with available time slots. However, new time slots/studies frequently become available so please check back again at a later date.

Currently Viewing: **All Studies**

View lab studies with available timeslots on : Tuesday, 22 September 2026 GO

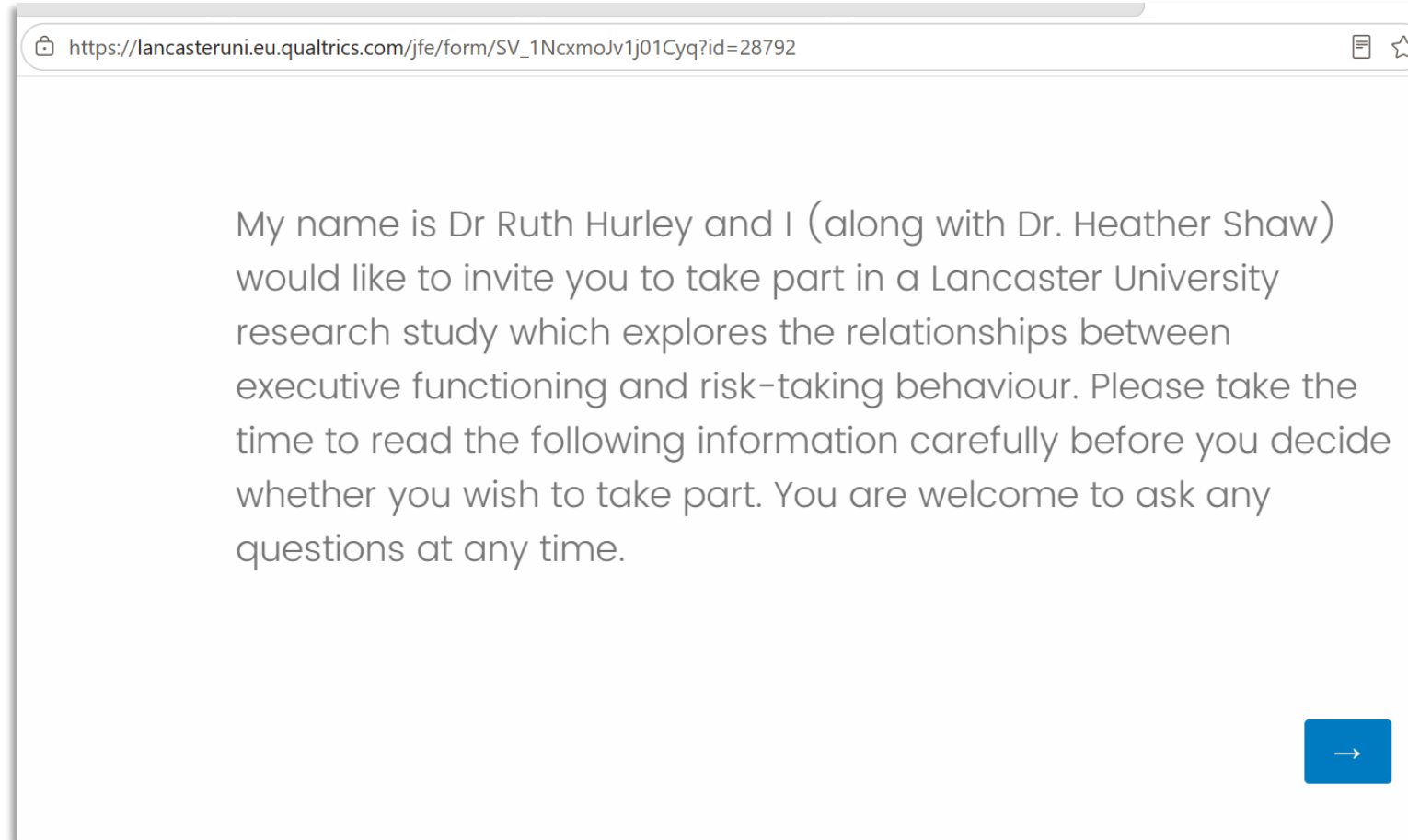
Available?	Study Information	Eligibility
Timeslots Available	73 Credits-Uncovering the spatiotemporal neural dynamics of sleep-dependent memory process (73 Credits) (2-Part Study)	PLEASE SEE STUDY DESCRIPTION FOR DETAILED ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENTS Prior study restrictions
Timeslots Available	25 Pounds-Uncovering the spatiotemporal neural dynamics of sleep-dependent memory processes (£25) (2-Part Study)	PLEASE SEE STUDY DESCRIPTION FOR DETAILED ELIGIBILITY REQUIREMENTS Prior study restrictions

NOW
Find and complete
the following study:

PSYC4141 Students Only:
The relationship between
executive functions and risk-
taking behaviour

Study:

The Relationship Between Executive Functions and Risk-taking Behaviour



The image shows a screenshot of a web browser displaying a Qualtrics survey form. The browser's address bar shows the URL: https://lancasteruni.eu.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_1NcxmoJv1j01Cyq?id=28792. The survey content is centered on a light gray background and reads: "My name is Dr Ruth Hurley and I (along with Dr. Heather Shaw) would like to invite you to take part in a Lancaster University research study which explores the relationships between executive functioning and risk-taking behaviour. Please take the time to read the following information carefully before you decide whether you wish to take part. You are welcome to ask any questions at any time." In the bottom right corner of the form, there is a blue rectangular button with a white right-pointing arrow.

My name is Dr Ruth Hurley and I (along with Dr. Heather Shaw) would like to invite you to take part in a Lancaster University research study which explores the relationships between executive functioning and risk-taking behaviour. Please take the time to read the following information carefully before you decide whether you wish to take part. You are welcome to ask any questions at any time.



Complete the Study

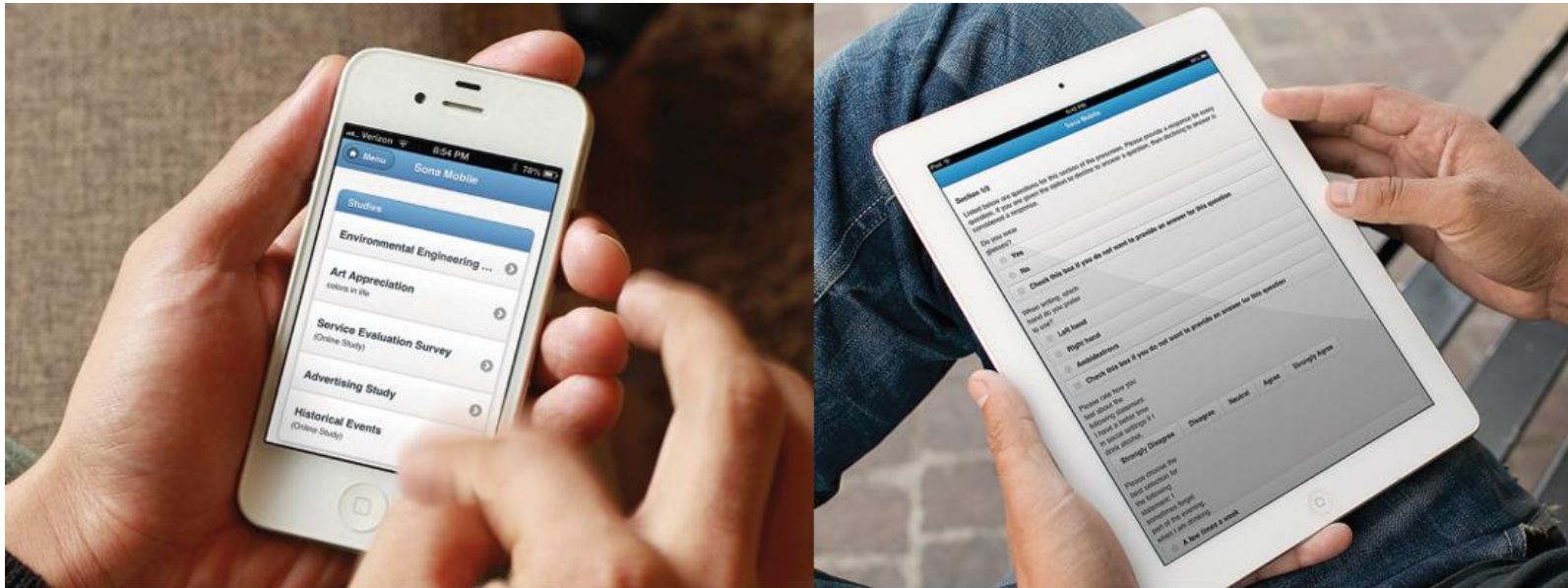
- You will receive 2 SONA credits.
- Remember to read the study de-brief.

**PSYC4141 Students
Only:
The relationship
between executive
functions and risk-
taking behaviour**

Bookmark the SONA website or You can download the SONA Participants App



Search 'SONA Mobile' on your app store



lancs.sona-systems.com

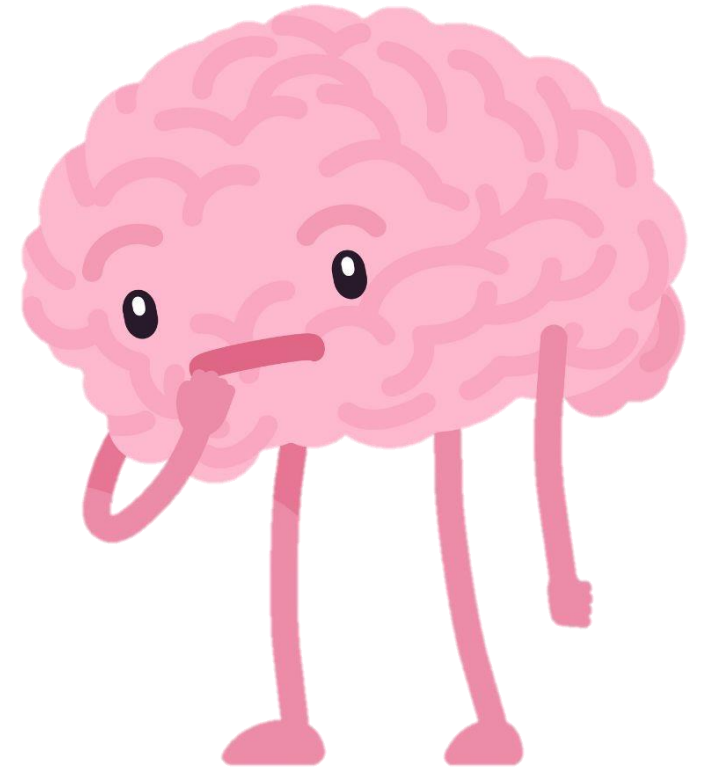
Tips on collecting your SONA Credits

For PSYC4141 and PSYC4242 Assessment



You want to **avoid**.....

- Losing marks by not getting your required credits logged.
- Preventing yourself from using SONA to recruit participants for your dissertation project by not getting your 120 credits.
- 3 unexcused no shows = temporary ban of the system.



Plan for getting your credits

- Don't wait! Don't Regret! You can't leave it until the last minute.
- Set your own incremental targets, e.g.

Term1

- By week 5, aim for 30 credits collected
- By week 10, aim for 60 credits collected

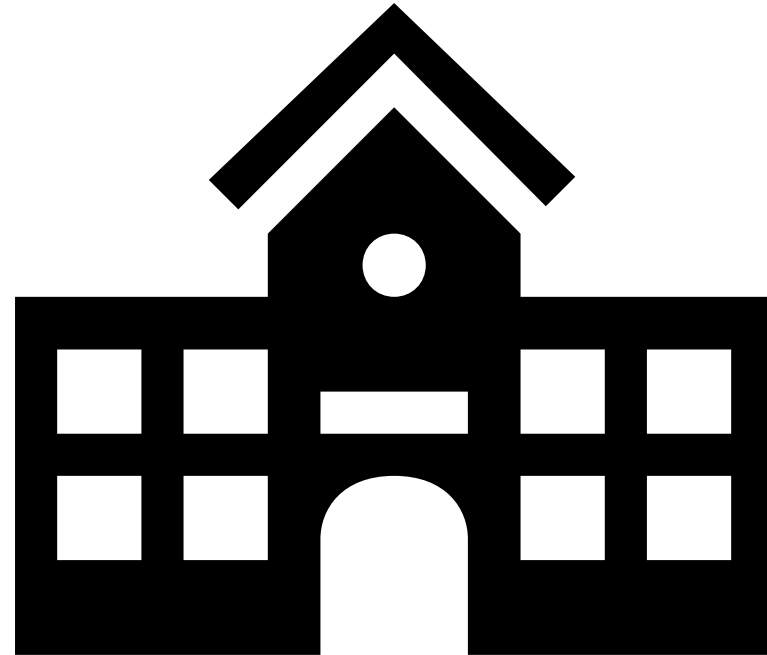
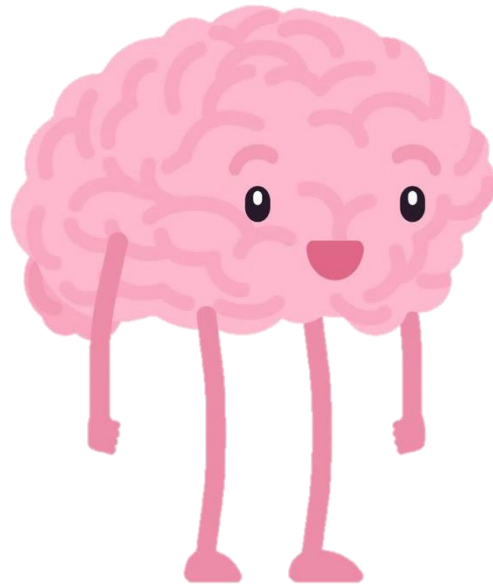
Term2

- By week 14, aim for 30 credits (90 total)
- By week 18, aim for 60 credits (120 total)



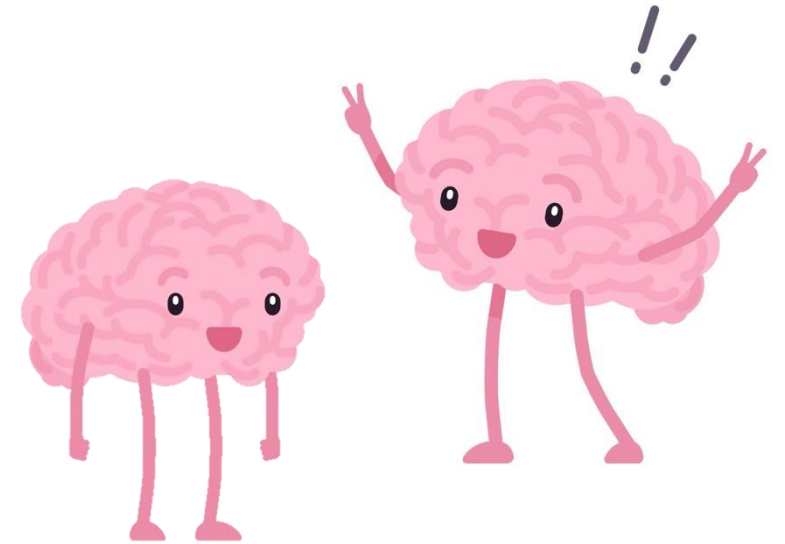
Make it **easy**!

- Do from the comfort of your own home if you are doing online studies.
- Do 2/3rd less work by coming into campus and taking part in in-person research. Remember **in-person research** is worth 3X more credits.



Make it **fun** and social!

- Show off Psychology to a non-psyc friend – Get them to sign up to SONA and take part in a study.
- Sign up with your friends and chat about the study afterwards.
- Pick studies you are interested in. Ask about their methods, and what inspired the project.
- Reflect – what makes a good research experience for participants?
- Treat yourself to some paid research along the way.
- Use money from paid studies for a treat or to go out!

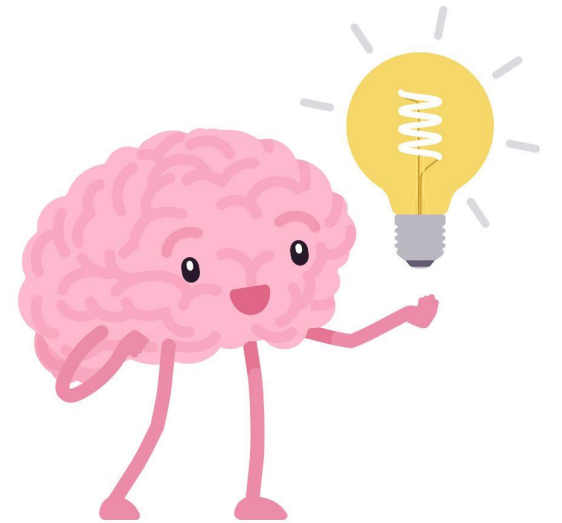


Make it **timely**!

- Already on campus? Book a study for just before or just after a lecture.
- Pick a time each week when you will review and sign up to available studies.
- Many studies have flexible hours. Email the researcher for times outside what they have advertised.
- You could do lots of quick/short studies.
- Or longer studies can get lots of credits in one go (so if you get behind in choose some in-person studies to catch up).

Make it happen!

1. Sign up to another study now!
2. Bookmark the SONA Website (or DL [the app](#)).
3. Look at your timetable and identify times you could take part in studies on campus.
4. Write a plan – How many credits are you going to try to collect per week, and on which weeks (most Y3 studies will appear in January).
5. Create a weekly event in your calendar telling you to check SONA.



SONA Support1

Lancaster Account Problems?

[IT account | ASK - Lancaster University](#)

- [LU SONA Information](#) for Participants and Researchers.
- Online FAQs (via SONA)
- Online [SONA support pages](#).



SONA Support2

You can email us if a researcher isn't granting you a credit in a timely manner (or giving you payment),

or

if you are having problems with your SONA account.

Email:

SONA@lancaster.ac.uk

Example Subject: Y1 SONA login problem

If you aren't emailing us from your LU email account, please make sure the email includes

- your first and last name
- your course e.g. *Y1 Psychology Degree*
- your LU email e.g., J.Smith@lancaster.ac.uk
- or your LU username e.g., SmithJ@lancaster.ac.uk

Apologies in advance for slow replies, especially during busy periods